

Seawall height in Miami Shores

The elevation your city requires, the datum it is measured in, and the section of code that says so.

MIAMI SHORES • MIAMI-DADE COUNTY

4.0 ft NAVD88 (5.5 ft NGVD29); recommended foundation for future 5.0 ft NAVD88

The minimum seawall elevation is 4 ft NAVD88 (5.5 ft NGVD29). Owners are strongly encouraged to design the foundation so the wall can later be raised to at least 5 ft NAVD88. Substantial repair (50% or more of the wall value within one year) triggers the minimum for the full property length.

The detail

MINIMUM	Minimum seawall elevation shall meet 4 ft NAVD88 or 5.5 ft NGVD29 - Miami Shores Code App. A (Zoning) Sec. 560(d)
FUTURE - READY	Strongly encouraged foundation for future extension to min 5 ft NAVD88 or 6.5 ft NGVD29 - Sec. 560(d)
SUBSTANTIAL REPAIR	Repairs at 50%+ of wall value in a one-year period must meet the minimum for the continuous wall along the property - Sec. 560(e)
IMPERMEABLE	Walls must be substantially impermeable to tidal water - Sec. 560(c)
MAINTENANCE	Seawalls must be kept in good repair - Sec. 560(f)
ADOPTED	Ord. No. 2018-04, 20 Feb 2018 (drafted as Sec. 600, renumbered 560)
BAY AND CANAL DEVELOPMENT	New development on land next to Biscayne Bay, the Biscayne Canal or other bay tributaries needs special approval, with site plans reviewed for natural vegetation at the water's edge, detention of the first inch of stormwater and no floodplain filling - App. A Sec. 534
SETBACKS FROM THE WALL	Where the plot line runs into the canal or bay or over the seawall, setbacks are measured from the landward edge of the seawall cap, or the top of riprap placed under Miami-Dade County Code Ch. 24 - Sec. 534(4)

Where this comes from: Miami Shores Village Code of Ordinances, Appendix A Zoning, Sec. 560(d); App. A Sec. 534 (Waterfront lands)

Verified: 2026-10. Rules change — check the date above against today.

Before you call a contractor

1 Know your datum

A height means nothing without the datum it is measured from. NAVD88 and MLW are different reference points and the same wall gives different numbers in each. Ask which one any quoted elevation refers to.

2 Get the existing elevation surveyed

You cannot tell whether a wall meets the requirement by looking at it. A surveyor shooting the top of the cap settles it in an hour.

3 Ask what triggers the requirement

Most cities only apply the minimum to new walls or to substantial repair. What counts as substantial is defined differently in each city, and it is usually a percentage of length or of cost.

4 Ask about building higher now

Several cities require a wall built below the final figure to be engineered so it can be raised later. Doing it once is cheaper than doing it twice.